of the forthcoming birthday of one of his siblings. Rajeev pleaded with me to delay the operation by forty-eight hours. 'I'll get him for you,' he said with determination. I looked over at my 2iC, who concurred with this assessment. 'Let's delay it,' he said. The Company Commanders had already been briefed, orders would remain unchanged; the only difference being that we would go in on the night of Thursday/Friday. In fact, added the 2iC, the terrorists would have been alerted that something was in the offing, since all the Company Commanders had assembled at the HQ, hence the delay might actually lull them into a false sense of security. And that is exactly what happened.

Mustafa Khan

The trap was sprung at the crack of dawn. The counterterrorist troops under my command that had been lying in wait all night in the emerald green paddy field rose as one and moved towards the suspect village. As they closed in, there was a flurry of movement inside the hamlet. The Company Commander, Capt Rajeev Bahuguna radioed me that he was moving in. Coming across a maulvi who had gone to the mosque to give the morning call to prayer, he asked him, '*Baba, kya dalel cheu*?' (Father, all is well?).

The old man was too petrified to answer even this simple greeting. The officer knew he had hit pay dirt. '*Baba*, what is the matter?' he asked. 'Is there anyone in the mosque?' The poor man did not know what to say. Besides being a maulvi, he had performed the Haj as well. He did not want to lie outright.

'*Beta*, it was dark when I went to the mosque. How would I know?'

'But do you guarantee that there is no one inside the mosque?' insisted Rajeev.

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